but also institutionalized a more liberal relationship with the country's Hindu majority. [25] This was a major step in the evolution of Indian civilization. Although it is today considered politically incorrect to see it in these terms, it is difficult to deny that, before Akbar, there was a 'clash of civilizations' element to Hindu–Muslim interaction in North India. This is evident from both the writings of Muslim authors of that time as well as from the Hindu response to the Turkish invaders.

Take for instance the dogged resistance to the Turks by the Rajput-ruled kingdom of Mewar in southern Rajasthan. The rulers of Mewar did not see themselves merely as kings but explicitly as the custodians of Hindu civilization embodied in the temple of Eklingji, a manifestation of Shiva. The deity was considered the real king of Mewar and this is why its rulers did not use the title of Maharaja (which means Great King) but that of Rana (i.e. Custodian or Prime Minister). It is important to recognize this if one is to understand why Mewar kept up continuous resistance to the Sultans despite suffering extreme hardship over centuries. On three separate occasions, its capital Chittaur was defended to the last man and, even after it fell, the struggle was sustained in the hills. One cannot explain away this behaviour merely in rational political terms.

In order to comprehend this state of mind, one must visit the shrine of Eklingji, less than an hour's drive from Udaipur. It is a thousand-year-old temple complex wedged into a hillside. If one walks around in the surrounding Aravalli hills, it becomes obvious that they are heavily fortified. The fortifications of Chittaur, Kumbhalgarh and even Udaipur are within a few hours' drive. Mewar must have been the most militarized place in the medieval world. It tells of a population that considered itself under siege and was prepared to hold out to the end.

By the time Akbar appeared on the scene, however, centuries of conflict had left both sides exhausted. Thinkers like Guru Nanak, the founder of the Sikh tradition, had already put forward arguments for civilizational accommodation. Emperor Akbar probably had a naturally liberal disposition, but his thoughts also evolved with time. The tipping point may have been the siege of Chittaur, the capital of Mewar, in 1568. The fort fell